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About 1000 words

What the Walls Know

There is a crack in my bedroom ceiling that runs from the light fixture to the left wall, stopping just short of the corner as though it thought better of going any further. I did not make this crack. Whoever lived here before me did not make it either, probably. It is the kind of damage that accumulates slowly, invisibly, the way a house settles into itself over years. I have lived beneath this crack for years now, and I have stopped noticing it. That is how it works. You move into a stranger's history, and eventually you stop seeing it.

The house is a rental, which means it belongs to someone else in all the ways that matter legally and most of the ways that matter practically. Three bedrooms, one bathroom, tile floors in every room except the second bedroom, where a previous tenant laid down laminate wood that does not quite match the rest. I know this because the laminate ends abruptly at the doorway, transitioning to cool beige tile with the bluntness of a decision made on a budget. I have wondered about that tenant. Were they trying to make the room feel warmer? Did it work?

The kitchen has four different cabinet styles, which tells you something about the house's age and its owner's incremental attempts to maintain it without committing to a full renovation. One set of upper cabinets is white with silver handles. Another is off-white with brass. There is a single low cabinet beside the refrigerator painted the faint green of a dollar bill, as though it

arrived from a different kitchen entirely and never quite assimilated. I keep my cleaning supplies in it. It feels fitting somehow, storing the things nobody wants to see in the cabinet nobody can explain.

Out the back door, there is a live oak that drops leaves year-round, which is the peculiar defiance of the Southern live oak: it is called “live” because it stays green while other oaks go bare, dropping its old leaves only when the new ones push them out. I did not know this until I moved here. In November, when I expected the yard to go quiet and brown the way yards do in the places I had lived before, the oak kept its green and littered the ground instead. I spent a Saturday morning raking in a season that did not look like a raking season. There is a lesson in that, though I have not yet decided what it is.

I have made my marks on the house too, though I am careful. I hung three picture frames in the living room, driving small nails into the wall at angles I measured twice. They sit beside a constellation of older nail holes, some patched with spackle that does not quite match the paint, some left open, small dark mouths in the drywall. I tried to hang my frames at heights that would cover some of these holes, the way you arrange furniture to hide a stain on the carpet. The result is a living room that tells two or three stories at once, none of them complete.

There is an inventory one might take of this house that would tell you nothing real about living here. Three bedrooms: one for sleeping, one repurposed as an office, one kept in a state of uncertain becoming, full of boxes that have not been unpacked in forever because to unpack them would be to commit to this address in a way I am still negotiating with myself. One bathroom with a showerhead that runs hot but not scalding, which I have decided is adequate. A washer and dryer in a closet off the kitchen, stacked and whirring on Tuesday evenings. Blinds on every window, the horizontal kind, three of them broken in ways that make them tilt at angles that let in morning

light whether I want it or not.

And then there is the other inventory, the one harder to write down. The smell of the house after rain, something mineral and green that comes through the back door screen. The sound the floors make in the hallway at night, a specific sequence of creaks I have memorized without trying, the way you memorize the rhythm of a sentence you have read too many times. The quality of the light in the late afternoon, when it comes through the right-facing windows and turns everything amber for about thirty minutes before it shifts and is gone.

I read somewhere that houses remember. Not in any mystical sense, but in the sense that every space accumulates evidence of occupation: wear patterns on floorboards, grease near light switches, the faint impressions of furniture legs in carpet. The house knows every person who has passed through it in ways those people never knew they were communicating. I walk through a room in the dark and my feet find the same path every time, wearing something faint and invisible into the floor that some future tenant will follow without knowing why.

What I am trying to say is that a house is not yours, not entirely, even if you own it outright. You inherit it from people who shaped its walls and broke its cabinets and drove their own nails and left their own shadows in the corners. And add your layer to theirs. You become part of the record.

The crack in my bedroom ceiling has not grown in years. I have checked. It may be finished, or it may simply be moving more slowly than I can perceive. Either way, I have begun to think of it as a fixed point in a space that is still becoming mine. When I leave, it will stay. Someone else will move in beneath it, look up, and stop seeing it eventually, the way we stop seeing anything we have learned to call ordinary.

Author's Note

When I chose to write about my current living situation, I was drawn less to the house itself than to a question the house seemed to carry: what does it mean to occupy a space that was never entirely yours, rather your turn with it? I live in a rental, which means the house existed before me and will continue to exist after me, and that impermanence has shaped everything about how I experience it.

The essay I wanted to write was not a floor plan or sentimental portrait. I wanted to locate the “other thing” that Brown describes, the thing underneath the thing. For me, that meant writing about the layered quality of an inhabited space, the way a house accumulates traces of every person who has lived there and becomes a kind of palimpsest. The cracked ceiling, the mismatched cabinets, the uncovered nail holes: each is a material record of someone whose name I do not know.

I used the inventory device as both a structural tool and a thematic one. The literal inventory of the house (rooms, appliances, fixtures) functions as a counterpoint to the less tangible inventory: sounds, smells, light, the muscle memory of walking the same hallway in the dark. I hoped the tension between these two modes of accounting might express something true about how we actually experience the places we call home, through both the measurable and the felt.

My central aim was to render the ordinary experience of renting a house as something philosophically resonant without overstating the stakes. A house is not a profound subject on its face. But I believe the act of paying close attention to any ordinary thing can uncover the questions embedded inside it. I chose this prompt over the Jacksonville prompt because I wanted to work at a smaller setting, one house rather than a city, trusting that a small enough container might hold something larger. That is what I tried to find here.

